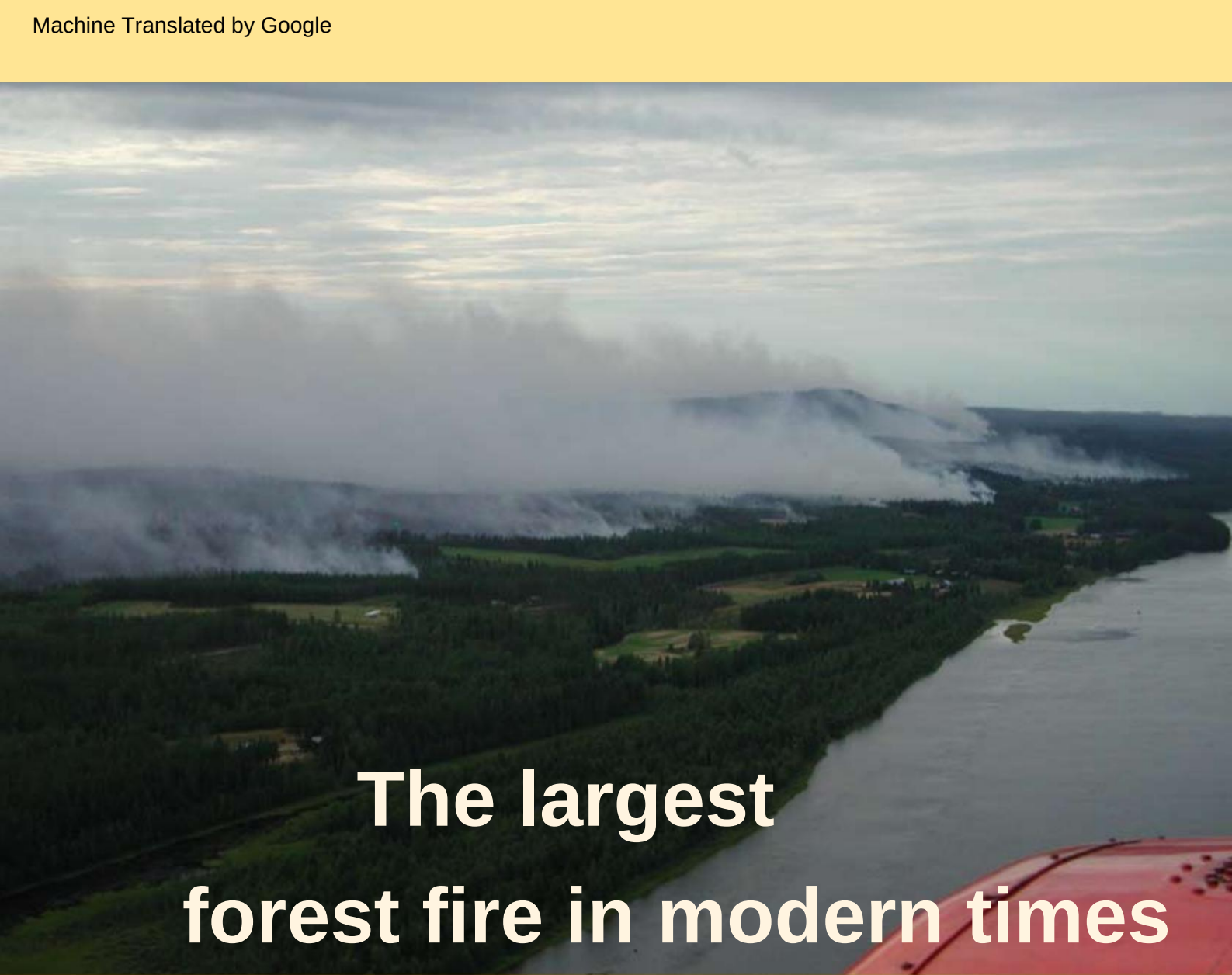




The largest forest fire in modern times

Bodträskfors, Norrbotten

2006-08-11–2006-09-08

The fire day by day

Follow the progress, the frustration and the fight against the flames from day 1.

Personal eyewitness accounts

10 votes from rescue workers, landowners, municipal
management and volunteers.

Experiences for the future

Read and learn from the accumulated experiences.



Bodens
kommun

The smoke has cleared.

The rescue team has begun to recover. Eighty miles of hose are under cover. But the scars from the largest forest fire in modern times will remain for generations.

All of Sweden was talking about it. Everyone in the area was shivering in the middle of the deserted Norrbothnian summer. But few have understood the extent of the enormous forest fire that raged in Bodträskfors and the surrounding area at the end of the summer of 2006. Apart from the forest owners who were forced to watch the heritage and work of several generations go up in smoke, and the house and cottage owners who were forced to flee their homes without knowing if anything would remain. And of course everyone who toiled in the summer heat to fight the fire and help with all the work that was required around.

was taken by fire. To some extent, luck, and sometimes bad luck, was on our side. But to a large extent, we can also learn from the efforts and choices that were made during the most critical days. With hindsight, we can see that some choices may have made things worse. Others made changes for the better.

In this document you can follow the progress of the fire and the efforts day by day, as well as read personal interviews with some of the people who worked in and around the forest fire in Bodträskfors from August 11 to September 8, 2006.

Hot facts about Sweden's largest forest fire in modern times

Time: The fire raged for four weeks.

Area: 1900 hectares = 3000 football fields = several times larger than the town of Boden = takes two hours to drive around by car. 2500 cubic meters of wood were cut along 16000 fire roads.

Staffing: Rescue services from all the county's municipalities except Kiruna and Pajala came to help. They also received reinforcements from Sundsvall, Örnsköldsvik, Malå, Ånge, Skellefteå, Lycksele, Storuman, Finland, Södra Roslagen and the rescue service from F21. In total, approximately 750 man-days worked on extinguishing the fire.

Volunteers: The volunteer resource group had up to 30 people/24/7 to transport food, personnel, refuel cars, etc. 30 people from the Home Guard helped, mainly with firefighting.

Catering: The kitchen at I19 was responsible for food for the rescue crew. A maximum of 160 meals were served per shift at the fire area and 20 at the fire station in Boden.

Material:

- 80 km of hose was in circulation, of which 3200 hose lengths of 25 meters were used. (For a "normal" forest fire, about 40 hose lengths are used.) It required 180 days of work and about 100 SJ pallets to take care of afterwards.
- 40 motor sprayers of 2000 liters/min (pulled by car)
- 1 flood jet of 6000 liters/min (came from Finland with personal)
- 150 jet tubes
- About 10 portable syringes
- 100 steel piassava brooms
- 100 churches/branches
- 130–140 water jugs
- It took 4 trucks to transport all the material back.

The fire day by day

Day 1, 2006-08-11 Friday At

06.05 the Boden Rescue Service receives an alarm about a forest fire in Bodträskfors. Five men from Harads' part-time fire brigade have been working to put out another forest fire just a few kilometres away all night and announce that Boden must take it. But three of them are sent as a rescue team and two stay to continue to put out the fire. They have to search for a while before they find where the fire is and start putting it out at seven o'clock with the equipment they have in the rescue truck while waiting for Boden. The fire area is then about 300 metres long and 50 metres wide and follows a forestry tractor road. It is burning 30 metres behind a forestry machine and they get hold of the landowner and machine owner to have the machine moved. The machine was left at 1 am and no smoke was seen at that time. However, it is reported that the night staff at the care center alerted SOS about smoke from Västbohället at 3 am, but at that time it was believed that the smoke came from a previous forest fire in Odjursberg.

A full-time firefighter from the area on his way to Boden in the morning turns back and comes to help the Harads school children. Shortly after 7 o'clock, the rescue team calls out to Boden again. After a whole night of fighting, they are tired and need help. A car with a hose is then sent from Boden. When Svea Skog takes over the monitoring of the fire at Storklinten, which parts of the rescue team had left, the other two come from the force and there are now six people plus two volunteers in total. They pull the hose along both sides of the fire and check for backup so that the hose does not burn out. 08.57 Boden is pulled part-time and 10.13

Five men arrive by car. Then they start to have the fire under control, so while the first team goes for a coffee, the newcomers continue with the extinguishing work. When the water is turned on, it doesn't work on the right side and it turns out that one of the hoses has burned out. Everyone runs there to help.

Rapid change

At the same time, it blows and in the middle of the firefighters, patches of ground fires flare up in the 1.5–2 meter high sleet and 50–60 meters in front of them. The ground here is usually wet but not this summer. In a very short time, the fire is uncontrollable. The rescue leader on site orders to save what can be saved and for everyone to get out on the road. Everyone runs away from the fire and two firefighters get burned in the face.

An ambulance is called but no one is seriously injured. They try to stop the fire and call for more help. Hose and fittings are burning inside.

Two cars leave from Boden with the front line taking over.

Water and hose are requested and a rear command with a rescue chief on standby (RCB) is established in Boden.

Later in the morning, another critical situation arises when two tractors and a barracks get in the way of the fire.

The machines have already been moved once, but the fire spreads and the machine operators are caught and told where the keys are. The rescue personnel manage to get both the machines and the barracks to safety.

Gammelstad's rescue service is called in and arrives at 3 p.m.

They start by changing out of their station clothes and summer shoes, and change to winter clothes after a while of extinguishing the fire.

In the afternoon, the fire is extensive and more resources are requested. Boden's full-time fire department goes out with two cars and a tracked vehicle.

Helicopter and Home Guard requested

RCB talks with ARCC in Gothenburg regarding the defense helicopters. At 13.40 I19 is contacted to request the Home Guard. You are referred to ATK in Uppsala. 30 Home Guardsmen arrive.

At 3:25 p.m., no helicopter has arrived and one is requested again.

At 5:25 p.m., the Home Guard reports a fire at the top that cannot be extinguished with their equipment.

The helicopter, which was also needed for a forest fire in Överkalix, will not take off until after 6 p.m.

Initially, there are natural firebreaks. It is decided to widen the firebreak at Klusåvägen and the harvester who was on site from the beginning is working on this.

The helicopter arrives just before 6:30 p.m. but has problems and starts again an hour later. The helicopter reports that the fire path is well downwind and that there are 800–1,000 meters left to the front. The ridge is extinguished by the helicopter. At 8 p.m. the helicopter leaves to refuel and is gone for just over 1 hour. During that time, the distance to the front has reduced to 400 meters. The extent of the fire is estimated to be 2.4 km long and 400 m wide.

The helicopter is flying over the area and cannot see the road but continues to extinguish what is visible.

Gammelstad's rescue service is sent to Boden to look after the station. Boden's full-time night shift takes over from the day shift. At 10 p.m.



By this time, Harad's part-time force is completely exhausted and Vuollerim's part-time force will come to relieve him. At 11:00 p.m., the entire area is considered stable and the demarcation line holds.

Day 2, 2006-08-12 Saturday

At 05.50 the situation is still considered stable. A full alarm is raised at Gunnarsbyn for relief. Jokkmokk is also being prepared for a response. At 10.00 scattered islands are burning and a helicopter is requested again. It arrives at 12.54. Just over an hour later it is announced that the helicopter's flight time is about to end.

Four major fires are discovered and it is described as "burning everywhere."

A new crew is requested for the helicopter but they are told that a new helicopter may arrive earlier.

gast 17:00. It takes time and only at 19:13 the helicopter loads the bucket with water and can arrive at the fire within eight minutes. At 21:00 the helicopter has to depart to refuel and is gone again for an hour.

Logistics for fuel, water and lunch are arranged by the rescue service's own personnel shopping and ordering food delivery from restaurants.

The wind blows and even more fires are discovered during the afternoon. At the same time, there is a fire in Muddus National Park where the rescue service in Porjus is sent.

Day 3, 2006-08-13 Sunday

The extent of the fire increases in just a few hours to about 500 ha. About 1000 ha are restricted to prevent the fire from spreading.

Early Sunday morning it looks like the firebreaks are having an effect. Another 150 meters and the entire fire will be surrounded.

A breakpoint, fuel depot and communications point are being set up in a garage in the village of Västbo during the morning. Approximately 20 people from the rescue services in Boden, Luleå, Råneå, Piteå and Älvsbyn are participating in the extinguishing work with the help of 15 home guards. At half past ten in the morning, the fire road is clear and is now only 40 meters from the fire.

At 11.08 the helicopter, the Swedish Defence Force's Puma H98, arrives. During the morning the pump located at Bodträ-skån stops working while the fire rapidly moves closer and closer to the boundary line and the buildings at 5 m/sec. At 11.35 the fire is heading towards Västbo at a violent speed. At 11.50 it is determined that the fire is uncontrollable and an attempt is made to contact residents in Västbo to warn them.

Brandgata at 8:21 p.m. Saturday, August 12





On Sunday afternoon, the fire quickly approaches the houses and evacuation is carried out.

Reinforcement in the air and on the ground

Porjus fish flight and Kallax flight are requested to supplement the first helicopter. A local machine owner is working on a new fire road south of Västbo. The road on the south side of the Lule River is closed and the public is advised not to visit the fire-ravaged area.

The Volunteer Resource Group, FRG, is called in and arrives with nine people at 2 p.m. A total of 15 FRG members work during the day. The first task will be to warn the residents of Kluså and prepare the school as a collection point for evacuees.

Practical issues arise, such as food for the rescue forces.

The lottery tickets are requested for cooking supplies, but they are directed to the kitchen at I19 and are told that the rescue service must arrange its own transport from Boden. FRG delivers the first food shipment.

The rescue team is requesting additional assistance from other rescue services in the county and Västerbotten.

Evacuation

Shortly after 3 p.m., evacuation of Västbo to Harads school begins. There, FRG receives and arranges refreshments. Forward command is established in Västbo. POSOM

The extent of the fire increases by several hundred hectares in just a few hours.

("mental and social care in the event of accidents or disasters") is called in, is on site during the evening and is then on standby while two people from FRG remain at the school all night. A total of 40 people are evacuated from the villages of Västbo and Klusån.

The information department is called in.

In the afternoon, the municipality's information manager is contacted and told that it is a big deal and that something must be done.

The information manager and the rescue manager meet at the station and discuss the situation. A press release is issued with information about the fire.



One concern is the difficulty in getting helicopters. At 10 p.m., we receive word that one helicopter can leave at the earliest tomorrow morning and that helicopter number two can arrive at the earliest tomorrow afternoon.

Other fires at the same time: Norriån, Notsel, Messaure and Mud-dus.

Day 4, 2006-08-14 Monday

20 men from Boden, Piteå, Luleå and Älvsbyn have a night shift in Bodträskfors. At 04.30 open flames are visible to the east above the buildings in Klusån. Flames are also breaking out in the southwest corner of the fire area. The helicopter takes out GPS points on the smoke-covered fire road in the north. During the night, Kallaxflyg supports the fire front.

During the day, two helicopters from the defense arrive.

Monday morning the rescue chief will have a briefing with the municipal management. The situation is unclear and the extent of the fire is increasing.

The Swedish Rescue Service arrives in Boden and is updated on the situation. The rescue chief goes up with the Swedish Rescue Service in a helicopter to survey the fire area.

From Vuollerim, some elderly people are being evacuated from a nursing home in Vuollerim who are having trouble breathing due to the smoke from Bodträskfors.

Fiskflyg and Kallaxflyg are deployed in separate directions. At midday, the fire is 50 m from the southern fire road. More FRG personnel are requested. Västbogatan is widened with a bulldozer. Shortly after 2 p.m., two forces, a tanker truck and a helicopter are requested and protective burning is discussed. The need for hose in various dimensions and other materials is great.

The media drive is on.

After the press releases were issued, media interest in the fire increased significantly. The rescue chief was called. There is also a lot of pressure at the roadblocks, which are guarded by the FRG. The first press conference will be held at 3:00 PM.

The municipal management meets and decides not to convene the Crisis Management Committee and to make the matter an Extraordinary Event.

At 18:20, preparations for counterfire begin, but the operation is called off when the wind changes and the risk is deemed too great. Finland is contacted for assistance with personnel.

Help from above

Shortly after 7 p.m., the Aeronautical Rescue Coordination Centre in Gothenburg (ARCC), which leads air rescue operations, announces that two helicopters from Linköping can be up at midnight with a departure time of 10 a.m. tomorrow. Puma H98 has run out of flight time, which means that the helicopters will have to be relied on until Thursday. However, the Pumas will fly until 10 p.m.

At 9 p.m. the fire is breaking through at Stora Kluså mountain with a risk to properties.

At 10:38 p.m. the status report reads:
North: risk of crossing the fire road, water bombed, South: Calm, East: OK, Northwest: crisis that it will cross, houses threatened Klusåberget, Björnudden, Björkvik bombed, risk of properties being set on fire. Personnel are being prepared from Gällivare, Skellefteå and Råneå.

Other fires: Lillvarjisträsk, Varjisträsk, control Norriån, Muddus (100 ha)

Day 5, 2006-08-15 Tuesday

The fire-ravaged area is now 800 ha. Excavators and a bulldozer are continuing to work to delimit the area. At 04.45 the fire front in the north is about 400 m from the boundary line. No property in Björnudden has burned yet. Two helicopters are water bombing.

Lövånger part-time fire brigade arrives.

The Puma takes off at 09.20. But a Super Puma must be repaired and test flown before it can be used. Another has a problem with the basket and must go to Kallax. The two promised helicopters are at midnight in Sundsvall due to fog and one has instrument problems. Both were supposed to arrive at 10, but it is reduced to one helicopter, the time is moved up to 12 but it does not arrive until after 13. The second helicopter will arrive at 16. Work is underway to get more helicopters for tomorrow.

More staff on the way

On the personnel side, reinforcements are coming from Råneå, Arvidsjaur, Gällivare, Skellefteå and Luleå, plus personnel from Boden and Harads. Älvsbyn's rescue service is also on site. Finnish personnel arrive but are forced to stay at the station overnight. Assistance is also requested from Södra Roslagen. In total, about 60 people are working on the extinguishing work.

Arrangements are made for weather reports to be faxed morning, lunch and afternoon from F21.

FRG will have a minibus at its disposal to transport personnel, food, etc. A total of 24 people work from FRG.

Top fire and punctures

11.36 it starts to reach the peaks in the southwest corner. Fiskflyg water bombs. The road between Bodträskfors and Klusån causes many punctures and has to be repaired.

Björnudden is being water-bombed during the afternoon, but there is a lot of smoke so it is difficult to see where the water is going to be released. The Skellefteå group goes there to guard the houses, and Beab is contacted to turn off the electricity. At 3 pm the wind is blowing towards Bodträskån and there is concern that the fire will jump the river. At the same time, a helicopter from West Helicopter is on its way to Västbo with a pod and another helicopter is ordered from Kallax Flyg.

Massive airstrike and passable road

At 16:35, two helicopters, a superpuma, two Kallax aircraft, a Vest helicopter and another helicopter are working in a grid according to the traffic control. The air operations are yielding results and the situation is back under control, but it is noted that more helicopters cannot fit in the airspace.

Almost the entire area is surrounded by a road that can be used with an off-road vehicle, except in the southwest corner where the situation is critical. An off-road vehicle is ordered and the rescue team is driving around the area.

FRG is manning the traffic posts. Hangars for material storage are being sought.

After 10 p.m., a helicopter pilot reports a violent fire at the lower boundary.

At 10:25 p.m. the helicopters leave the area for the night.

Media management is being sharpened

The municipality's information manager is called home from a conference in Överkalix. On Tuesday evening, the municipality sets up a media number where all journalists can get direct contact with people who are only responsible for information questions about the fire, which means a great relief for the rescue manager. The only problem is that the number has not been tested at night and that forwarding to a mobile phone is not possible.

Other fires: Varjisträsk, Pouttaure, Aspberget/Vuollerim (waterbombed by helicopter from the Bodträskfors fire).

Day 6, 2006-08-16 Wednesday

There is now a demarcated area of 3000 ha with firebreaks to the north, west and south and the fire is starting to be under control. The extent of the fire is estimated at around 1500 ha.

At midnight the situation is calm, 28 men are working, work on the boundary lines is progressing and is expected to be completed by morning. The wind is calm.

00.50 a Finnish newspaper wants information. The team gets a short briefing but the reporter wants to see the fire and the group turns out to be under the influence of alcohol.

02.10–03.10 Rescue leaders and task force commanders reconnoiter parts of the area by car. At 03.30 a helicopter goes up to search the area. Three more helicopters go up just after 4 to water bomb. The critical thing right now is the upper part before the demarcation line is completely clear.

The southwest corner is covered in smoke, nothing can be done there via helicopter.

After the recruitment round, three priority areas are identified, of which Norra Klusåberget is number one. 31 firefighters arrive from Ånge, Harads, Gällivare, Arvidsjaur, Råneå, S.Roslagen and Luleå during the morning.

At 4:50 a.m., four helicopters are in the air.

Air traffic control from the Armed Forces

Two military helicopters (Yngve 71) arrive and air traffic controllers from the defense take over helicopter coordination. The lines seem to be working but they want a contact route via radio to the rescue controller. The air traffic controller obtains an air radio which is picked up by helicopter and closed airspace is requested.

Södra Roslagen arrives and is assigned to build a water system.

The governor visits the station.

In the evening, a helicopter, a puma and three private helicopters are in the air.

A telecommunications technician manages to resolve the forwarding of the media number and the number is forwarded to an emergency mobile.

At 11:40 p.m. there are 3 water systems through the area, a total of about 12 kilometers.

More help from above and from the south

Norrträlje and Storuman rescue services offer to come and help.

In the afternoon, equipment and materials from the Swedish Rescue Service arrive. FRG has 27 people working.

A prayer service in Harads church is scheduled to be held at 6 p.m., with both the rescue chief and the municipal councilor participating. A few blessed raindrops will arrive as early as 5:15 p.m. and increase in strength.
Hallelujah!

Day 7, 2006-08-17 Thursday

At 04:00, water bombing begins with two helicopters from Kallaxflyg and one from Fiskflyg. At 06:00, water bombing by military aircraft begins. There are smoldering fires, but otherwise the situation is calm. It has burned all the way to Bodträskån, but the risk of spreading is over and the fire is being extinguished from the outside in. The biggest danger now is falling trees where the roots have burned off.

This means that no one is allowed to work further into the area than 50 meters. The fallen trees also cause problems with the electricity. About 20 poles have been blown down and in several places there are trees over the lines.

About 70 people are currently working on the fire on the ground and 21 People from FRG are serving all around.

Minister of Infrastructure Ulrica Messing visits the area and participates in a press conference in Bodträskfors at 1 p.m. She speaks with forest owners and raises the discussion about compensation land for those affected.

FRG is guarding the roadblocks so that no press enters the fire scene.

Forestry machinery begins clearing fire roads so that the value of the forest is preserved.

At 5:00 p.m., it is decided to reduce the helicopter force and from Friday onwards have one helicopter from 6 a.m., two helicopters from 10 a.m. to 4 p.m. and one helicopter from 4 p.m. to 11 p.m., and another helicopter all day. The Home Guard will begin disarming after Friday. It is also decided to reopen to residents from Friday.

On Thursday evening, five helicopters are flying at all times. Four forces are working from each side.

Muddus: Two helicopters water bombed during the day and the situation was brought under control. Surveillance was ongoing during the night with two men. The transport route was closed to tourists, etc. Total fire area about 300 hectares.



When the helicopters were deployed at full strength, it had an effect.

Day 8, 2006-08-18 Friday

At 4:00 a.m., the first aerial reconnaissance of the day is carried out, followed by a reconnaissance of the entire area by car.

Then a helicopter goes up for water bombing in area 6. Fog and smoke in other areas mean that they have to interrupt, but they continue water bombing with two helicopters starting in the middle of the day.

Four forces are working during the day. Örnköldsvik and Sundsvall are going home. The residents are being allowed back to their homes.

The forest fire brigade has decided to remain until Monday. The rescue service now has 14 cars, a quad bike and a demountable tank in the area. The FRG has 17 people working.

Nature reserve or not?

A helicopter tour is being made to find out together with the Norra Skogsägarna whether there is any forest to save in the area. Discussions are underway at a central level whether the area should become a nature reserve or not. If it becomes a nature reserve, nothing will be done in the area. If it does not become a nature reserve, there are areas in the northeast corner that should be surrounded by fire roads.

Roads leading into the area are closed to the public with cones and tape during the afternoon. Rain and thunder are on the way and the helicopter is taking a break for a while during the afternoon.

Trees are falling and it is dangerous to be in the area, and there is also a risk of material damage.

In the evening, F21 arrives with 5 men.

The evening helicopter tour shows a couple of small fires on the west side of Klusåberget and a couple of the same kind at Åbacka.

In the evening, 21 men are working to extinguish the area.



Where the fire has spread, trees are falling in all directions and it is life-threatening to be in the area.

Day 9, 2006-08-19 Saturday

The night patrols report that the night has been quiet with only minor fires. Smaller spot fires are visible in the early morning.

At 6:15 a.m. a helicopter and air traffic controllers arrive. Water bombing begins with spot fires at the northern line in Sector 1.



The occasional mishap leads to a smile amidst all the misery.

Here is a spontaneous fountain.

At 6:39 a.m. the helicopter reports that there is more smoke in area 3. Water bombing is continuing in that area, in connection with Björnudden. The greatest risk is behind Klusåberget where the water bombing is concentrated to prevent it from starting to blow. There are some spot fires where there is only smoke and in some places there is an open flame.

The Minister of Defense will

Minister of Defense Leni Björklund will arrive in the afternoon. The area will be cordoned off prior to the visit.

She lands at 5:00 PM and is briefed on the situation. She talks to the emergency services personnel, pilots, FRG and the affected forest owners.

After a helicopter flyover, it is assessed that no helicopter operations are needed during the evening.

At 7:20 p.m., smoke is reported to the north and straight down towards Åbacka.

Other fires: At 9:58 p.m., a major alarm goes off at the district heating plant, where four men go.

Day 10, 2006-08-20 Sunday

It is difficult to assess the area due to smoke haze. The fog lifts in the middle of the day and reveals scattered smoldering fires throughout the area. The helicopter is directed to the northeast area. There is quite a lot of fire on the edge of Klusåberget.



Just when you think the fire is under control, the wind suddenly changes and the fire shoots through the treetops. A group of firefighters are completely surrounded by smoke, can't see the road they're on and don't know if it's fire or just smoke in front of them. With the help of a helicopter, they are guided out and everyone escapes unharmed.

The fire has jumped over Bodträskån at the bridge and there are extensive embers at the foot of Klusåberget's eastern side.

Two helicopters are requested and operate during the day.

A helicopter goes up and bombs sector 5/6 until 8:30 p.m.

Local machine operators are working on fire road improvement measures.

Decisions will be made about two helicopters Monday-Tuesday.

After today's work, the Finnish forces from Tornio will return home.

After the evening count by car, occasional streaks of smoke are reported, a little more along the eastern side of Klusåberget and northwest of Björkvik.

Day 11, 2006-08-21 Monday

The first inspection round of the day at 3 a.m. shows a lot of smoke around the creek in the southern part and around the road, just above Västbo. There is also a lot of smoke from the Björnudd intersection and up towards the bridge over Bodträskån and below the bridge at Klusåvägen and in the northwest corner between the turning points. There are serious fires in two places.

20 men from F21, the Rescue Association of Eastern Norrbotten, Lycksele and Arjeplog arrive in the morning.

The fire brigades are now tasked with extinguishing the fire offensively from

the roads in their areas of responsibility. The warning about the danger of falling trees still applies.

The organization from today will change to Boden full-time from 8:00 PM, which will monitor the area during the night. On-duty rescue leaders are at the fire scene from 8:00 AM to 10:00 PM.

A meeting with landowners and machinery owners is planned for the evening. Among other things, the need to clear the roads in the fire area to reduce the risk of trees falling on personnel and vehicles will be discussed. Only then will cabin owners be allowed into their cabins.

At 16.03, Kallaxflyg arrives, makes an overflight and then begins water bombing.

Other fires: At 09.55 the helicopter leaves the area and goes up to Haparanda to search for a new fire site there.

Day 12, 2006-08-22 Tuesday

During the night, a small fire was extinguished between Björkvik and Klusån.

At 04.30 Kallaxflyg starts and waterbombs sector 4 but is interrupted by fog and continues in sector 3. The fog also means that you cannot drive in the area.

Day and evening it is water-bombed with Vertol and Kal - Salmon flight. A helicopter has engine problems and aborts.

20:00 FRG leaves the area for the day. At 21:30 Kallaxflyg cancels.

Other fires: 200-300 square meters burning at Junkerträsket. The small helicopter is moving and Älvsbyn is being sent out to it.

Day 13, 2006-08-23 Wednesday

At 09:00 a briefing is held with the forest owners. They are starting to tree-safe Klusåvågen and a machine has started the fire road above Björkvik.

At 09.20 a helicopter goes up and rakes. The forces are then regrouped. There is a lot of spot fires at the eastern turning point and eastwards, at Klusåberget and also the mountainside eastwards towards the intended fire route. Lycksele and Storuman have tracked vehicles and are entering that area. F 21 goes in and checks Snöselet. Kallaxflyg is working in the north, and when the second helicopter arrives at 12 noon it starts at Snöselet and extinguishes the fire south of Bodträskån.

Telia comes and receives information about where there are downed telephone poles, but cannot enter that area now.

The fires are flaring up again.

Several fires are increasing both in the north and south and are discovered at 12 o'clock. The fire in the north is taken care of by the helicopter and Lycksele, while Storuman takes the tracked vehicle and travels together with F21 and takes care of the fire in the south, west of the new fire road.

After 3 p.m. Harad's emergency group will come to support the others. There will be a total of 20 men. The Puma from the defense will also come.

During the evening, work is underway to extinguish the fire in several areas. A helicopter is extinguishing the fire in Snöselet, where there is heavy smoke around the shoreline, and F21 is fighting north of the bridge. In the south, the second F21 team is fighting the fire at the new fire road together with Storuman.

Boden's full-time staff get a tour of the area when they arrive and get an overview of the situation. They then take the tracked vehicle and drive onto the southern fire road and continue where F21 and Storuman end.

Misfortune

A helicopter drops the pod. Harads is tasked with finding it and only finds it at 9:30 p.m. Shortly before 9 p.m., F21 and Storuman leave the scene, leaving Lycksele, Harads and Boden full-time. At 9:30 p.m., Kallaxflyg ends for the day.

Day 14, 2006-08-24 Thursday

The morning starts calmly. There are only a few places with moderate smoke. Two firefighters from Gunnarsbyn and two from Piteå are participating in the airstrike. Two helicopters have been working on water bombing since the morning. Just before nine, all the assembled forces are out in their sectors.

Towards morning, the intensity of the fires increases. In addition, the Piteå fire brigade ends up in the wrong fire street with its hose deployment. The hose is left in place and the Piteå fire brigade is moved to the correct fire street, in the southern part of the fire area, northwest of Västbo.

Helicopters report intense fire

south of the bridge over Bodträskån. Personnel from Gunnarsbyn are taking care of this together with a helicopter.

During the afternoon, all areas calm down. In the evening, it is the same calm situation as in the morning and Kallaxflyg's helicopters are praised for the day's work.

Day 15, 2006-08-25 Friday

Calm night with a few small fires. At 6:00 a.m. two helicopters from Kallaxflyg start their water bombing.

At 10:00 in square 45-25 on the map, there is an open fire at the new fire road that has been built in the northeast corner of the fire area. Smoke from small fires can be seen on the west side of the fire road. These areas are being treated by helicopters about.

In the afternoon, small fires burn again in several places. Two fires have re-emerged along Bodträskån and are being handled by helicopter, which is otherwise working on the northeast and northwest sides of the fire area.

At 9:35 p.m. the helicopters land for the evening. At 10:00 p.m. the rescue leader returns to the station in Boden.

Day 16, 2006-08-26 Saturday

Small fires in the northeast and northwest, otherwise calm.

Two helicopters are operating during the day and are doing a good job. A new water system is being started up on a new fire road northeast of Stora Klusåberget.

At 6:50 p.m., Boden's full-time team goes to Klusån.

The helicopters operate all day.

Day 17, Sunday, August 27, 2006

The night has been calm but in the morning the fog is thick.

On the northwest side of the fire area, there are a number of fire centers that are being treated by helicopter. The area closest to Västbo after the southern fire road is also being water-bombed.

Shortly before 12 noon, Gunnarsbyn reports a larger fire along the road up to Björnudden. One of the helicopters is directed there.

15.00 one helicopter reports a fire under a power line north of Klusåvågen and wants help from ground troops. F21 going there in one of his cars.

When evening comes, there are only small fires in scattered places in the fire area.

At 9:00 PM the helicopters land.

A neighbor of the control center has found a cache of gasoline about 400 m south of the control center. A police report is being made and the milk jugs with gasoline are photographed on site and then taken to the control center.

Day 18, 2006-08-28 Monday

I19 informs that they are withdrawing the fuel that the repository has so far provided for the flight, and that the civilians will now have to solve it themselves. Civilian helicopters continue to work.

At 6:30 p.m., Boden's full-time (4 men) will arrive at Bodträskfors and part-time at the station.

Day 19, Tuesday, August 29, 2006

Piteå extinguishes in the northwest, Harads around Björnudden and F21 along the road towards the turning area at Björnudden. Two helicopters are bombing spot fires.

It is decided to cease forest firefighting operations at the fire in Bodträskfors. I19 announces that they are filling up the farm tanks with diesel/gasoline but are not leaving the aviation fuel behind and no personnel are present.

Kallaxflyg will be used 3 hours/day from Wednesday. We have the right to use them more if needed. The rescue leader on site keeps track of flight times.

Day 20, 2006-08-30 Wednesday

At 09:00, three forces are sent out – Piteå in the south, Ö.Norrbotten in the north and Jokkmokk in the middle area.

Helicopter tracking shows a calm fire area. But in the afternoon, water bombing by helicopter takes place for about two hours. All three groups report that the situation is calm by the end of the day.

Now it only smolders in the ground.



The helicopter is also a good tool for getting an overview of the area and the fire.

Day 21, 2006-08-31 Thursday

8.00 three forces arrive – Piteå 6 people at the southern fire road, Ö.Norrbotten 4 people in the middle area and 5 from Jokkmokk take the northern fire road. The hose pulling in the northeastern corner is reinforced and the ground area is extinguished.

There is a small fire at the fire roads in the northeast and south, as well as at Björnudden.

The helicopter flies around personnel from Sveaskog.

In the afternoon there are only occasional columns of smoke in the area.

At 3:30 p.m. the helicopter is left for service and returns the next day.

Day 22, 2006-09-01 Friday

The night crew has rolled up 2 km of 110 hose and has also tried to get to the fire source south of the bridge, but it was difficult terrain and dangerously dark so it is handed over to the day crew.

After air raids at 09.00, Piteå starts with small fires on the south side and Älvsbyn on the north/northeast side. Piteå splits up and some take a portable sprayer to try to get south of the bridge and extinguish there. The helicopter has been bombing with water for several days without success.

Lycksele and Storuman announce that they can come in with forces Saturday-Monday.

In the afternoon, an elderly couple is found living in a cabin at Björnudden. They have planned to hunt moose. The hunting area is within the boundaries and the couple is evicted from the area.

Day 23, 2006-09-02 Saturday

The night is calm. You see some smoke and go in and flush in some places. An unauthorized quad bike with two people on it was found in the area and quickly sped away.

At 08:30 three groups arrive, each taking their own area. It is very foggy so we cannot fly yet.

When the fog has lifted, one from each group follows the helicopter up to see their area from the air. There is a little smoldering everywhere. Storuman, Malå and Lycksele help each other out in different parts of the area.

There is a report that there is a fire in the forest by the wooden silo in Klusån. The helicopter goes there and water bombs. There was a lot of fire but it was easy to get to.

In the evening the helicopter discovers some new fires. The helicopter goes up and tries to put out two fires at Klusån just above Västbo. The other guys go to their areas and take care of their new fires.

Day 24, 2006-09-03 Sunday

Two groups from Storuman are working in the southern and northern corners. Lycksele is working south of the bridge. Aerial footage in the middle of the day shows that it looks calm. The helicopter is water bombing the edges.

Fog all morning but no rain. Smoke pillars everywhere as before. The next flight will find some new small fires after the southern line. Storuman will take care of them.

The continued extinguishing and monitoring is being discussed. They still don't dare to release responsibility to the landowners, there are too many small fires and columns of smoke in the area and no rain has come.

It is decided to continue as before with two forces during the day and one force at night, as well as a helicopter until Wednesday. Personnel and flights are being arranged for the coming days.

Day 25, 2006-09-04 Monday

Two forces during the day, one force at night.

Calm, just a small fire in the clearing.

The landowners are being prepared to take over post-surveillance. The Northern Forest Owners fly along to form an opinion.

Day 26, Tuesday, September 5, 2006

A few small fires here and there. Piteå takes care of 3. Råneå pulls hoses to the south. The helicopter is sent to bomb for about 1 hour in the forest above Björnudden.

The County Administrative Board follows up with the helicopter.



The fire's progress leaves behind a fire-ravaged area the size of 3,000 football fields...

In the afternoon there are small fires against some boundary lines.

Where Råneå is located, the terrain is very poor and impassable.

The day ends with Piteå and Råneå helping each other to lay a new water pipe.

Two new smoke plumes are rising in the northeast corner. They will be knocked down with the remaining flight time of the day.

Day 27, 2006-09-06 Wednesday

There is smoke from two areas – Björnudden up towards the mountain which Piteå will take care of, and above Västbo in the marsh where Råneå started yesterday. Luleå continues there.

In the afternoon, the helicopter takes care of a column of smoke on the east side of Klusåberget.

Very quiet in the area in the evening.

At 8:00 PM it's pouring rain!!!

Landowner takeover completed on Friday at 4:00 PM.

Day 28, 2006-09-07 Thursday

08.15 Luleå and Piteå arrive. All is calm at the air traffic control.

The helicopter waterbombs the edges.

Three or four small columns of smoke in the area in the afternoon, otherwise very calm.

The FRG and the helicopter will be dismantled in the evening. Two personnel will stay on Thursday night to guard the material.

Day 29, 2006-09-08 Friday

Material transport from the area. The transports will continue for three weeks and will be carried out by Boden's rescue service and Harads' part-time fire brigade.



Heard and happened during the fire

Amidst the human tragedy that the fire meant for the landowners and the gray, sooty lunar landscape that it left behind, one can still find the occasional glimmer of light in retrospect. Some comical stories, guardian angels where things could have gone really badly, a house with nine lives and much more...

A hunting lodge and a cabin in the area had the flames practically licking at them. But for some inexplicable reason, the fire has stopped 30 cm from the wall and the buildings have remained undamaged. But the toilet next door is a pile of soot.

Harads School's property, Björnudden, was burned down several times during the fire's progress, but it remains there to this day without any major damage to any of the buildings.

A Finnish photographer, overexcited, managed to get into the area and is said to have risked his life to get some real action shots. After a flight down from a tanker truck followed by an unprintable rant in Finnish, he was abducted from the area.

From an ecological point of view, the fire could provide interesting flora and fauna in the future and in turn attract a new group of visitors to the area. Already this autumn, a professor from Lund has been in the area for ten days to study the people and the forest in the area. And foreign campers in the middle of the lunar landscape had to be turned away from the area.

A TV reporter commented on one of the local interviewees' slow speaking style, and was met with the broadest possible response: "Well, then you can make the broadcast longer."



Bengt Nilsson, Boden Rescue Chief

Good preparedness but insufficient resources in Norrbotten

Rescue chief Bengt Nilsson had a sweaty end to his vacation, to say the least, with the task of extinguishing Sweden's largest forest fire of all time on his shoulders. This was at the same time that 450 hectares of forest burned in Muddus, which also belongs to his area.

– We basically emptied every single fire station in the entire county. Our own staff only lasted for two or three days, then they came from Fyrkanten (Luleå, Piteå and Älvsbyn) and Östra Norrbotten. We have helped each other before within Fyrkanten, but never to this extent, he says.

Fire stations from many parts of the country got in touch and offered invaluable help to relieve those struggling against the flames.

– For us, it simply meant that we could handle this for 30 days, says Bengt Nilsson.

Boundary lines and base

The overall tactic was to build up the water supply and contain the fire with firebreaks. A containment line was forced by the fire and the first assembly point had to be evacuated quickly. There was particular concern for vehicles parked there.

Then a base was established which turned out to be a stroke of luck. The garage chosen served as a base for food, rest, management, personnel changes and refueling and was the starting point for most of the operation.

A front line was built on site and a rear management at the station in Boden. Boden's rescue chief had the overall responsibility and took Luleå's rescue chief to help with staff recruitment in the back office.

– We have a collaboration agreement within the square and always put Boden, Luleå and Piteå with rescue leaders mainly from Boden in the front line, explains Bengt Nilsson.

Useful experiences

With hindsight, Bengt Nilsson notes that Boden's Rescue Service was and is well prepared for forest fires.

But when it gets this big, Norrbotten doesn't have enough resources. The biggest shortcoming is the lack of helicopters.

– We had two military helicopters already on Friday, but that was too few. Previously, we have had 50 helicopters 100 meters from here. We have had many discussions about it with the ministers who have promised to look over the resources in this part of the country, says Bengt Nilsson.

He thinks that the defense helicopters were slow to arrive. In retrospect, he also believes that if they had anticipated the onslaught of media that would ensue, the press number and the telephone numbers for this would have been set up earlier.

Marita Nilsson Vennberg, FRG

Sharp position instead of first exercise

“We were supposed to do an exercise, but it turned out to be a baptism of fire,” says Marita Nilsson Vennberg, from the Volunteer Resource Group, FRG. The group had recently been formed in Boden, but instead of a first exercise, they ended up in the middle of working on the largest forest fire in modern times.

On Sunday, August 13, two days after the fire broke out, rescue leader Kaj Nyström FRG Boden contacted Marita Nilsson Vennberg. Nine FRG members were quickly dispatched and their first task was to inform residents in the fire area of a possible evacuation. But in a short time the fire spread rapidly and before the information mission could begin, an immediate evacuation was decided.

FRG carried this out and received around 40 people. at the collection point at Harads school.

During the 30 days that the fire was at its worst, a lot of personnel were required. In addition to 23 of 26 from the FRG in Boden, FRGs from Luleå, Älvsbyn and Kalix also participated. In the most critical situation, there were 20–25 people per day from the FRG, then three per day.

Three shifts

During the first six days, FRG personnel worked in three shifts around the clock. Every day, there was one person from FRG to coordinate resources in the rear headquarters at the station in Boden, while one person took notes for the rescue service logbook in the front headquarters.

Other personnel from the FRG provided all conceivable services at the fire site, at the base and to some extent also at the station in Boden. This included everything from transporting food, personnel, materials, arranging drinking water in the heat, serving food and coffee, arranging Panadol and even arranging snuff for stranded firefighters.

Planning food and transportation

Food storage was a comprehensive issue that involved transporting a maximum of 160 portions three times a day,

plus evening coffee, from the kitchen on I19 to the fire scene seventy miles away (one way), and up to 20 portions to the station.

Marita Nilsson Vennberg initially had to take all food orders and questions to the kitchen via VB, but after a while he handed over direct contact to the kitchen.

– It was worth its weight in gold to have access to the kitchen. I basically had direct access to the pantry. The girls were absolutely fantastic at volunteering and were able to arrange that little extra for those who were working, like biscuits, chocolate, fruit and more.

She is also very impressed by how the people of Bodensee and the villagers came forward with help and materials, and businesses sent extra things in the way of food to support the work.

“You could ask for almost anything and get it,” she says.

FRG was also responsible for transporting personnel and vehicles between Boden, the airport and the fire area and after a few days received two minibuses at its disposal. With hindsight, Marita Nilsson Vennberg believes that such vehicles, proposed by the municipality, to be used by FRG in crisis situations, should be available more quickly so that people do not have to drive private vehicles into a crisis area, in this case on very bad roads.

She also saw that the rescue chief had needed to relieve using the phone much earlier.

Marita Nilsson Vennberg notes that the FRG in Boden had greatly benefited from having built up a good group feeling before they got their first assignment. The members had met once a month and discussed how they wanted to work and organize themselves and did things together.

– It felt like everyone was involved and that we had talked to each other beforehand. Many question marks were cleared up and now we saw the importance of FRG, says Marita Nilsson Vennberg.

Jörgen Lundgren, head of the Boden Home Guard Battalion

Home Guardsmen on site after an hour

From the Home Guard, around 30 men participated per day throughout the first week.

– We brought in people from both Boden and later also Luleå's home guard battalion, says Jörgen Lundgren, head of Boden's home guard battalion.

The Home Guard was called in to the fire at an early stage, on the first day. They requested 20 men. An hour later, more than 20 men were there, equipped for a forest fire.

– Normally, we come with our hands and feet, but the more we know in advance about what is involved, the better we can adapt. We have a lot of material and equipment within the Home Guard, says Jörgen Lundgren.

He acted as a liaison between the Home Guard and the Rescue Service and led the Home Guard groups throughout the first week. The Home Guard worked mainly on firefighting and had around 30 men working every day.

As for everyone else involved, this was the largest assignment they have had in modern times, but the Home Guard has previous experience of extinguishing forest fires.

During the first weekend, Boden's home guard personnel were enough. sonal, but then they also had to bring in from Luleå.

Jörgen Lundgren thinks that the collaboration with the Rescue Service went very well. However, in retrospect, it has been discussed that the management team should also include a representative from the Home Guard, to improve communication.

– Now we made sure that I was at the briefing every morning and after that I was out in the field working, explains Jörgen Lundgren.

He also says that if they had known how big it would be, the Home Guard would have been able to contribute more material, cooking gas, vehicles, etc. from the beginning.

Jens Enberg, land and machinery owner

Harvested and lost forests

Jens Enberg volunteered to help cut fire roads from Friday evening and drove one of four harvesters that made fire lines from Sunday. At the same time, his family was evacuated from their home in Klusån and lost 270 hectares of forest to the flames.

Jens Enberg first helped as a volunteer by cutting with a chainsaw all night into Saturday and all Saturday when the harvester that was in the area initially started with the fire streets. Jens Enberg is a landowner in the area and lives in one of the villages that were evacuated. He is also a contractor in forestry machinery and on Sunday offered to bring his machine to the fire area. It was towed there and Jens Enberg's machine then ran basically around the clock until the fire streets and boundary lines were finished on Wednesday.

In total, three private harvesters and one from Svea Skog, nine excavators and tracked tractors were at full speed to fight the fire and the clock. The work was coordinated by Norra Skogsägarna, who was in contact with the rescue team. The rescue team was sometimes also in direct contact with the machine operators.

– It was terribly smoky working there. We had to work against the wind so the smoke was straight on, says Jens Enberg.

At times, it was even mentally difficult to cut down forests that he himself had once planted. Or to fly over to navigate through fire streets and see his ancestors' and his own forests in ashes.

– It was tragic.

Near the house

On Sunday he was at home for a while while another driver drove his machine. Then the decision was made to evacuate.

His wife and daughter were not at home, and Jens Enberg took the computer with the company's accounting with him and went to the family's cottage on the other side of the Lule River.

– On Sunday evening it was really close. Ten men from Boden were standing there watering the yard at home, says Jens Enberg.

From the cabin they saw how the entire Klusåberget was in flames on the other side of the river and of course there was the thought that their house could catch fire.

New Forest

Jens Enberg lost 270 of his approximately 300 hectares of forest.

During the ministerial visits to the fire area, there was talk of providing replacement forest to landowners and turning the fire area into a nature reserve.

– It was a whale. We have never heard anything more since and none of us landowners have been contacted. But it is not relevant for any of us private forest owners here. We have hunting here and don't want any reserve by the house. I will cut down everything on mine and plant new ones, says Jens Enberg decisively.

Kaj Nyström, rescue leader

“ARCC slowed down”

Kaj Nyström worked as a rescue leader during the fire and was initially the rescue manager on standby. He was called at 12:30 on the first day of the fire and was then involved in the entire process. He experienced it as ARCC slowing down when requesting helicopter resources.

In the weeks before the large forest fire in Bodträskfors, there had been a number of smaller forest fires in Norrbotten. Just a few days before, there was what was considered to be a large fire of 13–14 hectares, just a few kilometers from Bodträskfors.

When Kaj Nyström was called to the Bodträskfors fire, he quickly realized that helicopter resources were needed. As early as 1 p.m., he contacted ARCC in Gothenburg, which is responsible for the Swedish Armed Forces' air rescue.

Kaj Nyström was then informed that there were no helicopters available. He requested one again after 3 p.m. At 3:55 p.m., ATK in Stockholm, which is responsible for other defense resources, called. They questioned whether a helicopter was really necessary.

“I felt like ARCC was slowing down,” says Kaj Nyström, who believes that helicopter resources are not requested if they are not really needed.

– We have a cost responsibility and we should primarily use the state's resources before we go out and request civilian help. You are also forced to make an assessment of how much you can save in relation to the costs, he explains.

The first helicopter of the Defence Forces did not arrive until half past six in the evening, over five hours after it was first requested. When the helicopters did arrive, there were initially some technical problems, short flight times, interruptions for refueling after a short period of work, and so on. This was at the same time as the fire was constantly increasing in strength.

– The first two small helicopters from the defense didn't move. It was just like dabbing a little water. I saw in front of me those big “buckets” that exist, that was the size of

“I checked to see if we could get one in Europe, but there were about a hundred fires in Spain and southern France, so it wasn't possible,” says Kaj Nyström.

Protective burn planned

On Monday afternoon, it was decided to carry out a protective burn. Experienced personnel were brought in and preparations began for the operation in the evening. None of those involved had carried out such a large protective burn before, a total of three times four kilometers. But before the work could begin, the wind changed and the operation was called off as the risk was considered too great.

– But already on Monday evening I felt that this was going well. Then we had wide, nice fire streets, says Kaj Nyström.

And on Tuesday afternoon, when all the helicopters, at most seven, including two helicopters with larger water tanks, worked at the same time as the smaller ones that could work faster, it had an effect.

Clarity and relief

Kaj Nyström, like others who were involved in the most hectic and critical days, has had time to think through what happened, what was done and what could have been done differently. What he sees as the biggest obstacle was the problem of getting the helicopters. But he also points out that the Rescue Services must be very clear about what is needed.

He also sees that a lot of time was spent on press management in the first few days and that the press release should have been put out on Sunday when they realized it would be big. He believes that this press release should always be up and running so that it can be used as soon as something major happens.

Kent Tuoremaa, Chief 1 Helicopter Squadron F21

The help from above yielded results

The church's prayers for rain were all praise, but the most effective firefighting was by helicopter once the helicopters were deployed at full strength. However, there was a call for a flight coordination frequency that would work for both civilian and military helicopters.

Major Kent Tuoremaa, commander of the 1st Helicopter Squadron, F21, became involved in the helicopter flotilla's response command on the fifth day of the fire. From the ground, he worked as the response commander for the helicopters and their work on the fire during the first two weeks of the fire.

During the first day on Tuesday, two HKP4s, one HKP10 and one HKP9 from F21 were deployed to the fire. During Wednesday, two HKP4s (V 72 and Y 68) also arrived in the area. During Wednesday, the extinguishing work from the air had a better effect, partly due to the number of helicopters that water bombed, but also through the choice to have two heavy helicopters work simultaneously in area by area.

The area was divided into eight smaller areas. The intention of The initial idea was to spread the resources across different areas and achieve geographical separation between the helicopters. However, due to the progress of the fire, it was necessary to allow more than one helicopter in a coordination area. However, it became easier for the crews to coordinate internally with an area division.

At most, seven helicopters were working simultaneously, four of which civilians, with water bombing the fire, plus a Hkp 9 for general advice. The fire became controllable during the latter part of Wednesday and from Thursday, August 17, the operation was carried out in the form of water spraying of the fire sources that had arisen and subsequent extinguishing in the area.

Coordination and communication

– Already upon arrival at the operation area, we could see that flight coordination had to be arranged with so many

helicopters deployed in an area that is limited from an aerial perspective and has poor visibility due to smoke, says Tuoremaa.

This was done with experienced personnel from the traffic management in Luleå.

– A big Achilles heel was that from the ground we couldn't

maintain contact with all helicopters on the flight coordination frequency used in the air between the helicopters.

The rescue leader and his rescue team had everything else in the way of communication but no VHF radio. There should be one at every command post, says Kent Tuoremaa.

The connection was instead made on rescue radio channel 73 to those who had it, and in some cases on mobile phones or via signaling to civilian helicopters.

On Wednesday, they managed to find a sufficiently good aviation radio that had coverage throughout the area and, with the help of ATS (Air Traffic Service), established "Västbo Information" for the coordination of air traffic in the area.

Another difficulty was informing all crews about What was arrived at through coordination. It was solved by disseminating information, which did not have to be released all at once, gradually during refueling.

– An important experience we learned was that the rescue leader also needs to be informed fairly quickly about how long he can use the helicopters and that he also needs to understand that the deployed helicopter might disappear in 5 hours for service, says Kent Tuoremaa.

In conclusion, however, he notes that the task was solved in a very good way.

– We have experienced and competent staff and the cooperation with the rescue services has worked very well.

Kurt Ögren, rescue leader and materials coordinator

Eighty miles of hose and four trucks of material

Eighty kilometers of hose and four fully loaded trucks with material... That says a lot about the extent of the fire. For several weeks after the fire died down, the rescue services worked to pull in all the hose and well into the autumn, they worked on washing, testing and repairing.

Kurt Ögren was called in as rescue leader on Saturday, the day after the fire started. His task was also to act as materials coordinator and procure and direct the handling of all materials required by the fire. Some deliveries went to the Rescue Service in Boden, others directly to the area of operation.

– The first few days it was from neighboring municipalities, but then "That wasn't enough, so it came from all over the country," says Kurt Ögren.

A large part of the material came from the Swedish Rescue Services Agency, which was connected already on day three and then the deliveries rolled on from there. Among other things, a large forest fire depot in Småland was used, which was intended as a contingency for the storm-stricken Småland.

Organisation

At the station in Boden, a firefighter was responsible for the orders from the Rescue Service, he arranged a hangar for the F21 as a storehouse and also ensured that the arriving forces were accommodated.

Depending on the type of material involved, some was delivered to the forces at the fire scene, while other items were collected by the fire department themselves at the "garage" in Västbo, which served as a base for food, rest, refueling and rescue management.

The miserable terrain and circumstances took a toll on vehicles and materials.

– Maintenance and repairs were arranged by the rescue leader requisitioning spare parts that were sent up and, if needed, also someone who could fix it. What we could repair ourselves was often done by the night staff during the night so that we could drive again in the morning. We took the tracked vehicle down and repaired it in Boden, says Kurt Ögren.

Empty pumps

Refueling first took place at Bilisten in Harads, until they were faced with the unpleasant problem of running out of fuel at the pumps. The defense then provided two tanks for the garage in Västbo, one of which was gasoline and the other diesel. From the first Sunday, they also had a tanker truck with aviation fuel in the area so that the helicopters could refuel on site.

Major rework

When the rescue forces were able to leave the fire area, the gigantic task of taking care of all the material that had flowed in from the Swedish Rescue Services Agency and other rescue services in the country remained.

– A guy from the Swedish Rescue Service came up and was here for two days and helped distribute their material. He deserves a lot of credit for that, because it made things so much easier, says Kurt Ögren.

Washing and pressure testing all the hose has also been a time-consuming task, which several rescue services have had to help with. Getting the right things to the right rescue service has also not been the easiest.

– One thing you have learned is to label your stuff properly, not just with a dot, because several people may have done the same thing, in the same color, says Kurt Ögren.

Olle Lindström, Boden municipal councilor

Great benefit from training in crisis preparedness

The municipality of Boden had planned to do a large exercise in which all organizations would participate. Now instead, they had to test their organization in a real situation in and around a fire that galloped towards residential buildings and villages and spread smoke for several kilometers. A great asset was the training that the municipality had recently had in emergency preparedness.

Municipal councillor Olle Lindström, who is also chairman of the Boden emergency preparedness committee, was notified of the fire at an early stage. As the fire accelerated in scope on day two, Olle Lindström's involvement in the work was expanded to include receiving a status report on the fire every morning and evening during the most critical period.

He was also given the opportunity to follow along and fly over the area and see the extent for himself. The fire was assessed to be under control thanks to the extinguishing work both from the air and on the ground, and with functioning containment lines. On day four, the municipal management therefore decided not to call in the Crisis Management Committee and to make the matter an extraordinary event. However, POSOM ("mental and social care in the event of accidents or disasters") went in and was at the collection point together with FRG, the Volunteer Resource Group, during the evacuation of the affected villages.

– If it had gotten even worse, so that we had to evacuate all of Bodträskfors, for example, we would have done things differently. But now we felt like we had it under some control, even though the area was large, says Olle Lindström.

He also met with the Swedish Rescue Service staff during their days in Boden and Bodträskfors.

– They praised our organization and thought it worked very well, says Olle Lindström, who also believes that FRG made a great effort.

One issue that has been discussed internally afterwards is the mass media pressure and some believe that the media number should have been introduced at an earlier stage.

– We assessed that we had managed to put out the fire after the first "The situation was tense for about a day, but then it turned around and flared up. And it's possible that they could have come in earlier with the information, but I still think it was good reporting," says Olle Lindström.

Calls for education

Personally, Olle Lindström believes that all administrative managers and civil servants involved in major accidents and incidents in the municipality benefited greatly from the training they received in emergency preparedness just a few months before the fire.

– We had two days of training where we went through everything about what obligations you have according to the law, how to handle the issues in order, and we also had practical exercises on mock events where we had to discuss and think through different scenarios, he says.

The municipality of Boden has already received inquiries from other municipalities and will go out and be helpful in such matters, including by participating in similar training courses in other municipalities.

– That training was incredibly important and I can truly recommend it to other municipalities.

Reintroducing forest firefighting flights

Olle Lindström spoke with the Minister of Defense when she was here visiting the fire area and discussed the necessity of reintroducing forest firefighting flights. The county governor has also promised to influence decision-makers on this issue.

– It is my hope that the experience of this summer's fire will result in a decision about fire monitoring during the dry summer period, says Olle Lindström.

Ulf Leijon, Södra Roslagen Fire Protection Association

Good cooperation

– The collaboration with Norrbotten worked very well, excellently, says Ulf Leijon, who was part of the ten-man force that arrived from the Södra Roslagen Fire Protection Association.

On Wednesday, day six, the reinforcements that came from the furthest away arrived, ten men from Södra Roslagen and ten from Sundsvall.

They worked in groups of five people each and were responsible for themselves for their division of labor and scheduling.

– The fire department that is in place is so burdened. Then it is good to bring in people who are further away who do not have to think so much about everything around also having to function despite having a pressured personnel situation. This type of cooperation is something that we in the rescue services should include in our basic planning and create resources for. This is something we should have done a long time ago, believes Ulf Leijon.

The forces from Södra Roslagen came with rescue clothing for forest fires but requisitioned other equipment on site.

Something he found particularly positive was the FRG's efforts.

– The volunteer resource organization was great. They helped and fixed everything possible and it was never stuck.

During the five days that Södra Roslagen helped with the extinguishing work, he believes that the organization and layout of the work worked well, with cars, food, accommodation and other materials.

– The only thing that could possibly have been better is radio communication at the scene of the accident and well-functioning channels that we could be reached on via radio communication on site. But it was still possible as we had private mobile phones with us and could be reached via them.

Patrik Bylin, Luleå rescue chief

Start from scratch and dare to break patterns

That's according to Patrik Bylin, the rescue chief in Luleå and responsible for recruiting personnel for the fire in Bodträskfors. He turned to Stockholm and Sundsvall to get new, fresh personnel who could replace the local forces.

During the weekend, it became known in the county that a large forest fire was going on in Bodträskfors. The rescue chief in Luleå, Patrik Bylin, called his colleague in Boden to jokingly ask how sweaty he was. In response, he received "how soon can you come?". Patrik Bylin then became the one who worked side by side with the rescue chief in the back line and was primarily responsible for staffing.

– It was easy to get people there. First we did what we usually do when it's a big deal, we went to neighboring municipalities and then to Västerbotten, he says.

Forces from the south

Since work was carried out around the clock and people needed to rest between shifts, they soon realized that they had to look even further out to get more advance notice in the staffing, something they had never had to do before.

Patrik Bylin then contacted Janne Wisén at Södra Roslagen's fire department.

– I thought that in the Stockholm area, there must be there are a lot of people, says Patrik Bylin.

He also contacted Sundsvall. Ten men each came from both places, a total of 20 men, on Wednesday.

– We chose to take ten from each location, because then they have two of their own forces with a commander and four firefighters in each, who can work on their own schedule and manage the day and night themselves.

After that, many people from other rescue services in the country contacted us and offered their help.

– But we declined because there were no more tasks for us, says Patrik Bylin.

Review in Boden

The forces that came from other locations first arrived at the fire station in Boden. There, they held a briefing with a map of the area, went over overall tactics, and provided practical information about food, lodging, and more.

Some lived on I19, others at the station and some had to stay in a boarding house in Bodträskfors' neighboring village, Harads.

After a briefing in Boden, they were ordered to go to the front command post where they received their operational assignments.

– The demand for personnel was constantly based on the needs of front line, explains Patrik Bylin.

Start from the beginning

Patrik Bylin's experience of the work is that one should not be afraid to take resources from afar and break with traditional approaches. He believes that one must dare to start from the beginning when building up resources, both personnel and material, and have as early contact as possible with the Rescue Service in order to quickly obtain resources, but also for the financial follow-up. He believes that helicopters are crucial, partly for the extinguishing work, but also to get an overview. And like many others, he experienced that the media pressure became too great for the management staff to handle, and that the information center made it much easier. He also highlights the FRG's efforts as very significant.

Nils Sundberg, Head of Information, Municipality of Boden

Start early, think big

This is the advice and experience of Boden Municipality's information manager Nils Sundberg after the fire. With an information line manned by separate personnel, the rescue management was significantly relieved. Close cooperation between the information department and the rescue management then meant that the media could be handled smoothly and objectively.

When the fire started on Friday, August 11, it was still the holiday season. The municipality's information manager and the regular rescue manager were both on holiday. At first, it was thought that it was a regular forest fire, which was common during this period of this dry summer. The rescue manager and the information manager have previously had an agreement that the rescue manager will contact them when he deems it necessary.

On Sunday afternoon, Nils Sundberg was contacted and that same evening he met with rescue chief Bengt Nilsson.

"We agreed to have a briefing with the municipal management on Monday morning. The situation was unclear and the extent of the fire was increasing," recalls Nils Sundberg.

On Sunday evening, the first press release was issued by the municipality, on the municipality's website under "public information in the event of accidents" and via a news desk.

Nils Sundberg had an information meeting scheduled with the county administrative board, county council and the county's other municipalities at the beginning of the week and consulted with Bengt Nilsson.

– He said, "Come on, I know where I can get hold of you."

Whereupon Nils Sundberg ended up in Överkalix but was sent home. called on Tuesday when the fire had increased in scope and the rescue chief's direct number that was listed in the press release was called down by the media.

Information telephone

On Tuesday evening, Nils Sundberg set up a hotline for information on the current situation and planned measures. The number was opened on Wednesday morning and was operated from the Rescue Service's premises in Boden, where they worked closely with the rear command.

and had constant updates on the situation and what could be done. Three people worked here from 8 am to 10 pm every day during the first week. At night, it was not possible to transfer the call, but on Wednesday evening the phone was transferred to an emergency number.

Before the weekend, a staffing plan was made to be able to bring in knowledgeable staff and in 20 minutes the information department staff had the schedule ready.

– But the pressure from the media decreased so we never had to do it, says Nils Sundberg.

It was quickly seen that the media wave was at its greatest just before the morning, midday and evening broadcasts. The pressure also increased significantly when the Finnish forces arrived and with them the Finnish media.

Instead of regular press conferences, they tried to respond to the media via telephone and receive those who came to the Rescue Services and answer questions as they arrived.

No one was allowed into the control center. Often, journalists wanted to get in touch with personnel on the fire scene, and then a time was arranged for them to call or come outside the barriers to meet them.

– It worked well and there were clear rules of the game where everyone was loyal to the decisions. But I realize that if something had gone wrong, if a house or a person had been harmed, it would have made the task more difficult. But it feels good to know that we can continue to think as we did before the fire, says Nils Sundberg.

In retrospect, he can admit that if they had known what kind of onslaught there would be, the media number should have been put in earlier. They should also have registered where all the evacuees went, which was usually to family and friends, so they could have been reached easily.

Collected experiences from the fire in Bodträskfors

- Start early, think big.
- Let everyone concerned within the municipality be trained in crisis preparedness.
cabinet.
- Establish a media hotline early to relieve the rescue team.
management or have a press number running even when there is no crisis.
- Be clear on the part of the emergency services when requesting resources.
to be.
- ARCC and ATK – trust the rescue manager/client's assessment of what
resources are needed.
- Take every alarm seriously from the start.
- Don't be afraid to take resources from afar and break traditional
approaches.
- Start from the beginning, both in terms of personnel and material.
- Contact the Swedish Rescue Services Agency early, this will make things
easier both materially and financially.
- Let each person and organization do what they do best
on. Firefighters should put out fires, not shop for food, make coffee or
answer the phone.
- The Volunteer Resource Group, FRG, is doing a great job that would otherwise
have had to be done by fire personnel.
- As a rescue leader, a "hands-free" mobile phone is a must, as well as having
your charger with you.
- VHF radio for common coordination frequency for all helicopters from the
ground.
- Information that was not of an urgent nature was provided to
the crews during refueling.
- The rescue leader must quickly know what applies to the helicopters' flight
time, need for service, refueling, etc., in order to be able to plan the
operations and not suddenly be left without one or more promised
helicopters.
- Have the voluntary civilian groups well prepared and
together before the crisis comes. Discuss within the group how you will
organize and structure your work. Get to know each other well within the
group. Have a backpack with "nice-to-have" things from the start.
- Note where everyone who is evacuated is going so you can
reach them. Preferably a form that they can easily fill out at the collection
point.
- Include a representative from the Home Guard in the management group to
facilitate communication between the two organizations.
- Bring in a local person who knows the land to explain what the area looks like,
to avoid misunderstandings, driving errors, etc.
- Closer cooperation between the FRG and the Home Guard to
Use the Home Guard's resources in crisis situations (firefighting equipment,
vehicles, etc.).
- On occasions when even civilians, who cannot be reached via rescue
If the emergency services radio is involved, you should have the same
mobile number for those who take turns as rescue leaders so that they
can be reached quickly.
- Evacuated homes attract burglaries and there were mysterious cars moving
around the area and diesel was stolen at night. The first night after the
evacuation there were no roadblocks. You have to get up early.

